

HEMANT CHAWLA



DAILY CHORE: Pandey sweeps his office

Gandhigiri Gets Real

A Ghaziabad bureaucrat takes to cleaning his office in a bid to inspire citizens to follow suit

■ **By Subhash Mishra**

The commissioner of the Ghaziabad Municipal Corporation (GMC), Ajay Shankar Pandey, has taken up the broom. Inspired by the Mahatma, who used to clean his home, toilet and even his cell in the prison everyday during the freedom struggle, Pandey himself sweeps his office everyday, collects the garbage in a dustbin and empties it in a box outside.

The municipal commissioner of the fast-growing city of Ghaziabad, bordering Delhi, has taken a vow to keep it clean amidst the thousands of tonnes of waste generated everyday. "Certainly the city cannot be kept clean by 4,000 odd sanitation staff while more than 16 lakh people throw garbage on the streets," says Pandey. With highrise buildings sprouting in the city, the GMC has a hard time keeping the city clean even as scores of foreign dignitaries visit the city because of the 2010 Commonwealth Games that are to be held in Delhi and the National Capital Region.

"I decided to inspire people in my own way. I picked up a broom and decided to clean my office every morning," said Pandey even though this act brought about mixed reactions from his staff. Some dubbed it a drama while others were convinced and followed his example. Pandey remains un-



fazed and comes ten minutes early to clean his office. Sometimes his guests have to wait because the commissioner is finishing his chore.

"My humble appeal to the public is to spare 10 minutes every day for cleaning their surroundings," says Pandey. By his calculations, 16 lakh people spending ten minutes a day can create 160 lakh minutes of daily

cleaning without putting a financial burden on either the state government, the GMC or the individuals themselves.

Through another unusual measure, Pandey has halted corrupt officials in their tracks. The GMC now officially accepts "bribes" through a cheque. Under the earlier system, contractors had to give a 10-15 per cent commission—actually a bribe—to officials in case they would win a civil or an electrical contract from the GMC.

The commission is now routed to the corporation and this has made it richer by Rs 50 lakh in just six months. Pandey had used this method successfully during his earlier stint at the Gorakhpur Municipal Corporation. An offshoot of this measure is that contractors have improved the quality of their work and officials have stopped asking them for bribes.

Pandey has made a clean beginning in Ghaziabad. Hopefully babus in Delhi will take note. ■